

COMMONWEALTH OF PENNSYLVANIA
HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

STATE GOVERNMENT COMMITTEE

YORK COLLEGE OF PENNSYLVANIA
THE WEST CAMPUS COMMUNITY CENTER
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YORK, PA

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 13, 2021
4:14 P.M.

SOUTH CENTRAL REGIONAL PUBLIC HEARING
ON CONGRESSIONAL REDISTRICTING

BEFORE:

HONORABLE SETH GROVE, MAJORITY CHAIRMAN
HONORABLE RUSS DIAMOND
HONORABLE DAWN KEEFER
HONORABLE ANDREW LEWIS
HONORABLE BRETT MILLER
HONORABLE ERIC NELSON
HONORABLE CLINT OWLETT
HONORABLE FRANK RYAN
HONORABLE PAUL SCHEMEL
HONORABLE SCOTT CONKLIN, DEMOCRATIC CHAIRMAN
HONORABLE ISABELLA FITZGERALD
HONORABLE BENJAMIN SANCHEZ

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SUBMITTED WRITTEN TESTIMONY

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(See submitted written testimony and handouts online.)

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P R O C E E D I N G S

* * *

MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Good afternoon.

Today the House State Government Committee will convene the fifth of eight regional hearings across Pennsylvania on congressional redistricting.

Today we'll be hearing testimony about the southern central region of the Commonwealth. Thank you to York College for hosting us this afternoon.

As a matter of housekeeping before we get started, a reminder that each testifier will be given 10 minutes to present their testimony before the members of the committee. We'll be keeping firmly to these time limits. We're here to listen. No questions will be asked of testifiers.

Also, testifiers, please keep your comments relevant to the topic at hand.

We are here to learn about this region of the state, its industries, its values, and its unique communities of interest. And due to recent changes in sunshine law, subject matter of testimony must be confined to the hearing topic only. Testimony outside of this scope of the hearing will not be permitted.

We are here to learn from you and take your input on the congressional redistricts that will be in

1 effect for the next decade. This is an important task, so
2 if the testifier begins to stray from relevant testimony,
3 I'll ask you to refocus on the topic before us.

4 We also ask that testifiers speak clearly
5 into the microphone and that any attendees here in the room
6 with us today remain quiet and respectful.

7 Today's public input hearing is being
8 livestreamed at www.paredistricting.com. It is also being
9 recorded. Please help us ensure those who are watching at
10 home can easily hear all testimony.

11 Additionally, under the sunshine law, if the
12 video stream stops, we will recess the hearing until the
13 issue is fixed.

14 For the members attending virtually, please
15 ensure your microphones are off and recognize if your video
16 is on, so we can see you.

17 I would be remiss if I did not also mention
18 that in addition to the testifiers who are present today,
19 the committee has also received testimony from people all
20 across the Commonwealth who have submitted their written
21 testimony online. For the South Central hearing, we
22 received testimony from Kyle G from Quarryville,
23 Pennsylvania, Elizabeth R from York, Pennsylvania, Eric S
24 from Shrewsbury, Pennsylvania, Navia (phonetic) W from
25 Lititz, Pennsylvania, Michael G from University Park,

1 Pennsylvania, Randy File from the -- Adams County
2 Commissioner, and Daniel P from Dillsburg, Pennsylvania.

3 The written testimonies are before each
4 member of the House State Government Committee for today's
5 hearings and will be reposted online shortly after we
6 conclude.

7 I also want to remind people that written
8 testimony for the South Central region will continue to be
9 accepted online at www.paredistricting.com until midnight
10 tonight. So there is some limited time to still
11 participate.

12 And we finally begin. To our testifiers
13 both in person and whose testimony we have held in our
14 hands, thank you for taking an interest in redistricting
15 and for participating in this once-in-a-decade process.

16 Any opening comments?

17 DEMOCRATIC CHAIRMAN CONKLIN: That's good.

18 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: You're good?

19 DEMOCRATIC CHAIRMAN CONKLIN: I'm just
20 anxious to get started. And I want to thank the college
21 for having us here.

22 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Awesome.

23 With that, we'll turn to introduction of
24 members. We'll start to our right and then I will announce
25 members online virtually. I will ask that each one go one

1 by one, as we normally do.

2 Senator?

3 Thank you, Chairman Grove.

4 SENATOR PHILLIPS-HILL: State Senator
5 Kristin Phillips-Hill, 28th district.

6 REPRESENTATIVE KLUNK: State Representative
7 Kate Klunk, 169th district in southwestern York County.

8 Thank you to the Chairman for allowing
9 noncommittee members to join today.

10 REPRESENTATIVE MILLER: Brett Miller, 41st
11 district, Lancaster County.

12 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Again, Seth Grove,
13 196th district, York County.

14 DEMOCRATIC CHAIRMAN CONKLIN: And I'm Scott
15 Conklin, 77th district, Centre County, Penn State
16 University.

17 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Representative
18 Lewis.

19 REPRESENTATIVE LEWIS: Thank you, Chairman.
20 Representative Andrew Lewis here in the
21 105th district in lovely Dauphin County. Good to be here.

22 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Representative
23 Owlett.

24 REPRESENTATIVE OWLETT: Representative
25 Owlett, the 68th district, Tioga, part of Bradford and part

1 of Potter County.

2 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Representative
3 Nelson.

4 REPRESENTATIVE NELSON: Representative
5 Nelson -- there I am, a little bit overbleached --
6 Westmoreland County, happy to be here. Thank you.

7 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Representative
8 Fitzgerald.

9 REPRESENTATIVE FITZGERALD: Good afternoon.
10 Isabella Fitzgerald representing the 203rd Legislative
11 District, West Oak Lane, East Oak Lane, and the lower
12 northeast.

13 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Representative
14 Ryan.

15 REPRESENTATIVE RYAN: Representative Frank
16 Ryan representing the 101st district in beautiful Lebanon
17 County.

18 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Representative
19 Diamond.

20 REPRESENTATIVE DIAMOND: Good afternoon,
21 everyone. It's Representative Russ Diamond from the 102nd
22 district in beautiful Lebanon County.

23 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Representative
24 Sanchez.

25 REPRESENTATIVE SANCHEZ: Good afternoon,

1 everybody. I'm Ben Sanchez representing the 153rd district
2 in Montgomery County.

3 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: And that's
4 everybody virtually.

5 Representative Schemel, you want to say
6 "hi"?

7 REPRESENTATIVE SCHEMEL: Hello, everyone.
8 I'm Paul Schemel from Franklin County. Thank you.

9 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you.
10 Those are the members present today. And we
11 will go straight into testifiers.

12 First up is Lancaster Board of
13 Commissioners, Ray D'Agostino. Thank you so much for
14 attending. We appreciate your willingness to come out,
15 travel, and present testimony today.

16 So as long as that green light is on and
17 when you're comfortable and ready, the floor is yours, sir.

18 MR. D'AGOSTINO: Okay, looked like it was
19 on.

20 Good afternoon, Majority Chair Grove,
21 Minority Chair Conklin, members of the House State
22 Government Committee, and other attendees.

23 Again, my name is Ray D'Agostino. I am the
24 vice-chairman of the Lancaster County Board of
25 Commissioners. I appreciate this opportunity to provide

1 testimony today.

2 And the testimony I present today is in
3 regards to the upcoming congressional redistricting by the
4 Pennsylvania General Assembly and an imperative request to
5 maintain the entirety of Lancaster County in a singular
6 congressional district.

7 The County of Lancaster in its entirety is
8 currently in the Pennsylvania 11th Congressional District
9 and has historically been kept largely or completely within
10 one congressional district. The county is contiguous and
11 consists of a compact 984 square miles with defined
12 boundaries, and according to the 2020 census, a population
13 of nearly 553,000 people.

14 The 60 municipalities within Lancaster
15 County share a proud common history and a unique shared
16 bond which include many distinct characteristics and
17 continuities. Regardless of where you live in the county,
18 whether on a farm, in a suburban or rural township, a
19 borough, village, or in the city, invariably, we think of
20 ourselves as Lancastrians. This is not just a sentiment;
21 it is our sacred past and our hopeful future as expressed
22 by thousands of county residents and manifestly stated in
23 our recently adopted comprehensive plan, known as
24 Places2040.

25 In our Commonwealth, our nation, and even

1 worldwide, Lancaster County is known and celebrated as a
2 special place. Whether due to our unique and extremely
3 productive farmland, large Plain Sect population, or having
4 the oldest inland city in the United States -- which by the
5 way was a capital for the day -- the natural beauty of
6 waterways and wooded areas, or world-renowned manufacturing
7 rooted in ancestral industriousness, Lancaster County is
8 well-regarded and thought of as a singular entity.

9 Furthermore, Lancaster County has singular
10 entities that represent and make decisions on behalf of the
11 county as opposed to regional ones. For instance, meeting
12 federal guidelines and requirements, Lancaster County has a
13 singular metropolitan planning organization to plan and
14 implement transportation projects with federal and state
15 funds for the County of Lancaster.

16 The county also has a singular Workforce
17 Development Board. From time to time, there have been
18 discussions or proposals to split the County of Lancaster
19 into separate congressional districts; to divide Lancaster
20 County into two or more districts would divide us in
21 detrimental ways -- dividing our community, diluting our
22 citizens' voice in Congress, and creating new
23 administrative burdens. Planning and reporting
24 requirements along with the need to update federal agencies
25 driven by congressional districts, which you are located,

1 would hamper our effectiveness.

2 Given these facts, such divisions may well
3 violate fair redistricting principles that focus on keeping
4 communities with defined boundaries, like the County of
5 Lancaster, undivided and contiguous. Therefore, Lancaster
6 County respectfully requests and urges the general assembly
7 to maintain the entirety of the County of Lancaster in a
8 single congressional district.

9 To this end, and in a sign of our resolve,
10 the Board of County Commissioners adopted Resolution
11 Number 62 on August 25th, 2021, urging this outcome and
12 calling upon all elected officials in the Commonwealth of
13 Pennsylvania who represent the people of Lancaster to
14 support these goals and to commit to work towards passing
15 of such legislative efforts.

16 A copy of Resolution Number 62 was provided
17 along with this testimony that I've just provided. I thank
18 you for your time and consideration and important work on
19 behalf of all Pennsylvanians.

20 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you so much
21 Vice-Chairman D'Agostino. We really appreciate your time
22 today, your testimony, and we thank you again for your
23 time.

24 Thank you.

25 MR. D'AGOSTINO: Thank you, all.

1 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Next is Robert
2 Phillips, chairman, Lebanon County Board of Commissioners,
3 Lebanon, Pennsylvania.

4 And, Commissioner Phillips, when you're
5 comfortable and ready, and as long as that green light is
6 on, go ahead.

7 MR. PHILLIPS: Thank you.

8 Chairman Grove, Chairman Conklin, and State
9 Government Committee members, I'm Commissioner Bob
10 Phillips, Chair of the Lebanon County Board of
11 Commissioners and a business owner in Lebanon County for 31
12 years. I am here to urge that Lebanon County remain whole
13 as a congressional district preferably in Congressional
14 District Number 9.

15 We are currently part of Congressional
16 District 9 and Congressman Dan Meuser given us and
17 continues to give us excellent service. Lebanon County has
18 141,793 residents according to the 2020 census. A perfect
19 congressional district is 764,865 under the new census. So
20 for Lebanon County to have any real clout in a
21 congressional district, it needs to remain whole.

22 The county -- even whole, the county is only
23 19 percent of a congressional district. More
24 importantly -- and this is centerpiece of our reasoning for
25 wanting to remain whole -- we have three facilities in our

1 county vital to national defense and to our veterans. They
2 are Fort Indiantown Gap, the Lebanon Veterans
3 Administration Medical Center, and Fort Indiantown Gap
4 National Cemetery. Combined, these facilities employ over
5 3,000 area residents. But more importantly, Fort
6 Indiantown Gap is one of the largest training facilities
7 for National Guard and Army Reserve soldiers in the
8 country. We can also boast of having the number two
9 heliport operation for training in the country.

10 Fort Indiantown Gap was used heavily for a
11 staging facility for World War II division preparations and
12 was used for the same staging purpose for recent conflicts
13 such as Enduring Freedom and Iraqi Freedom. All three
14 facilities are interrelated, and if our county remains
15 whole, one congressional district will serve all three.

16 So important are these facilities to our
17 national defense and our veterans that in a prior
18 congressional reapportionment process, military and
19 community leaders asked our then-state senator to draw the
20 existing congressman out of our county because he was
21 unpopular with fellow congressmen, and they feared that our
22 facilities would be targeted for closure, an outcome which
23 would be devastating to our county, our country, and our
24 veterans.

25 For all the above reasons stated, I

1 respectfully ask you to keep Lebanon County whole in one
2 congressional district.

3 And I thank you for allowing me to testify
4 today.

5 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you so much
6 for your testimony today, Commissioner Phillips. We
7 greatly appreciate your time and willingness to testify on
8 behalf of the residents of Lebanon County. Thank you so
9 much.

10 Next is Roy Minet of Mount Joy,
11 Pennsylvania.

12 Roy, thank you so much for taking the time
13 and coming to testify this afternoon. When you're
14 comfortable and ready, please feel free to begin, and as
15 long as that green button is on, we'll be able to hear you
16 just fine.

17 MR. MINET: Good afternoon. I am a
18 physicist and an IT professional. I have researched all
19 aspects of elections over the last 14 years. I am not here
20 to plead with you to keep my county intact. I hope nobody
21 brought rotten tomatoes because my testimony is going to be
22 distinctly different, so I please beg you to keep an open
23 mind for the next 10 minutes.

24 Everyone is stuck in a deep rut; that rut is
25 channeling us towards a poor solution to the redistricting

1 problem. You have to rise up out of that rut to see that a
2 much superior solution is possible. The rut is caused by a
3 strong belief in a myth. The myth that everyone accepts
4 without thought or question is that it is a horrible thing
5 for district boundaries to divide political entities like a
6 county. That is simply not true and, actually, is
7 misguided.

8 I realize that you will choke on accepting
9 that, but it is correct. Again, I implore you to keep an
10 open mind.

11 Not dividing political entities stems from
12 the desire not to divide so-called communities of interest,
13 or COI, which are presumed to coincide with political
14 entities. There are two fundamental and fatal problems
15 with the notion that communities of interest should be kept
16 together. One of them is practical, and the other one is
17 principle-based.

18 The fatal practical problem is that COI is a
19 very nebulous and hard-to-define concept. Different people
20 will have radically different definitions. COIs could be
21 based on religious beliefs, political philosophies, single
22 hot-button issues, and countless other criteria. COIs as
23 defined by different people can and will differ and
24 overlap. Who's definition is to be honored?

25 Not dividing COIs is a poorly defined and

1 completely insoluble problem of impossible complexity. It
2 is an exercise in futility that obviously cannot be solved
3 by mere mortals whether they are state legislators or
4 citizens on a citizens commission.

5 The fatal problem of principle is that the
6 only possible valid reason why anyone would want to keep a
7 COI together is so that a representative who truly
8 represents their interests can be reliably elected. The
9 only way that can happen is if the members of that COI can
10 outvote the smaller number of those in their district who
11 do not share their same interests. That is the very
12 definition of gerrymandering which presumably we are trying
13 to prevent.

14 Please note that we have lived for decades
15 with districts which slice and dice counties in all manner
16 of arcane ways. We have suffered zero harm that was caused
17 by the division of political entities. However, we have
18 suffered harm. All of that harm was caused by contriving
19 the districts to keep communities of interest together
20 where the communities of interest are those who share the
21 philosophy of a specific political party.

22 In order to accurately achieve equal
23 population districts, the splitting of many political
24 entities is absolutely unavoidable. If splitting is okay
25 for some, why is it a problem to split others? One might

1 well argue that if some must be split, it would be much
2 fairer to split them all.

3 The only correct conclusion must be that
4 redistricting should be done impartially in a way that does
5 not systematically confer any advantage or disadvantage to
6 any specific faction or COI. It is also desirable to have
7 compact districts.

8 It really does not matter whether or not
9 political entities are divided except for the smallest
10 ones, which are voting precincts. Dividing voting
11 precincts would be unnecessarily disruptive as it would
12 force counties to redraw them, and that is not a trivial
13 burden. Since voting precincts consist of very small
14 populations, it is easily feasible to preserve their
15 integrity and still achieve equal district populations very
16 accurately.

17 Suppose we could write down a simple
18 procedure to draw electoral districts. That procedure
19 could be followed by anyone or a computer and that same
20 impartially drawn electoral districts would be the result.
21 And suppose that same straightforward procedure is to
22 impartially draw equal population districts very accurately
23 for any number of districts and for any state. The
24 procedure could be enshrined in the Constitution and there
25 would be no need to reinvent the redistricting wheel every

1 10 years. Redistricting could be done quickly, at a very
2 low cost, and without all the strife. No hearings would be
3 needed. Anyone could verify that the districts had been
4 correctly drawn.

5 Exactly such a procedure is shown on page 3
6 of this testimony. It has just five steps. It will never
7 divide voting precincts and always produces equal
8 population districts which are maximally compact. I do not
9 have the time to read through the procedure, unless you
10 wish to allocate additional time to do so.

11 In any case, those not mathematically
12 inclined will prefer to look at a visual illustration of
13 how the procedure works. I will use the remaining time to
14 do that.

15 Well, if Pennsylvania had just one
16 representative, there would obviously be nothing to do and
17 the entire state would be the one required district.
18 Page 4 shows Pennsylvania with two districts. The
19 procedure draws them simply by finding the shortest
20 possible line that divides the state into two sections,
21 each having one-half the population. Nothing could be
22 simpler or more impartial. If that line splits any voting
23 precincts, a simple rule determines on which side of the
24 line each split precinct is to be placed.

25 Page 5 shows Pennsylvania with three

1 districts. The procedure tells us to first draw the
2 shortest possible line that divides the state into two
3 sections, one having one-third the population and the other
4 having two-thirds of the population. Finally, the shortest
5 possible line is drawn which divides the larger section
6 into two districts, each having one-third of the
7 population. After each line is drawn, any voting precincts
8 that would have been split are placed entirely on one side
9 of the line or the other as determined by simple rule.

10 Page 6 shows Pennsylvania with four
11 districts. First, draw the shortest possible line that
12 splits the state into two sections, each having one-half
13 the population. Next, draw the shortest possible lines
14 that split each of those sections into two districts, each
15 having one-quarter of the population. For any number of
16 districts, just follow the procedure until the required
17 number of equal population districts has been impartially
18 drawn.

19 Page 7 shows Pennsylvania with 17 districts.
20 So if you grew with my procedure, we can stand down, we're
21 finished.

22 So, please, let's fix the redistricting
23 process simply, elegantly, permanently, and correctly by
24 using a guaranteed-to-be-impartial procedure that cannot be
25 corrupted by people.

1 Thank you very much.

2 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you so much.

3 And since we're done, I'll see you all
4 tomorrow.

5 Thank you so much, Roy. We really
6 appreciate your time and due diligence and the amount of
7 work it took to do that. Thank you so much.

8 Next, Jean Handley from Harrisburg,
9 Pennsylvania.

10 Jean, good to see you.

11 And Jean did testify in our second hearing
12 on behalf of fair districts. She was a substitute hitter.
13 She did a great job.

14 So thank you so much for joining us again.

15 MS. HANDLEY: Thank you, Chairman Grove.

16 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: And when you're
17 comfortable and ready, please begin, and just make sure the
18 green light is on.

19 MS. HANDLEY: It's on this time, yes.

20 Good afternoon, Chairman Grove, Chairman
21 Conklin, members of the House State Government Committee.
22 Thank you for the opportunity to appear before you today to
23 talk about the upcoming congressional redistricting in
24 Pennsylvania.

25 As you heard, my name is Jean Handley, and

1 although I am the Dauphin County coordinator for Fair
2 Districts PA, I appear before you today not in that
3 capacity, but as a resident of Dauphin County and a citizen
4 of this Commonwealth.

5 I submitted my written testimony previously,
6 and the testimony today follows that, however, for brevity
7 and clarity and to save the tedium of statistics, I've
8 modified my oral testimony a bit.

9 My focus today is on three areas to consider
10 when constructing the new congressional districts. One is
11 lack of choice or competitiveness in elections, two,
12 division of counties, and three, division of school
13 districts.

14 I'm going to start with election choice and
15 competitiveness. When speaking to groups and individuals
16 over the last four-plus years, I have repeatedly heard
17 statements like "why bother to vote when my vote doesn't
18 matter" or "there's only one candidate running, so they
19 already won this general election and their primary, so my
20 vote is meaningless." With close primaries in
21 Pennsylvania, this is especially noted by independent
22 voters. Voter frustration and disillusionment are
23 palpable.

24 Democracy is based on as many eligible
25 voters as possible lending their voice to the conversation.

1 And I'm going to cite the PA congressional general
2 elections from 2012 through 2020 as reasons why many voters
3 hold these beliefs.

4 And a note here, a win margin of greater
5 than 10 percent is widely used as a standard to determine
6 the competitiveness of an election.

7 Of the 90 PA congressional general elections
8 held during this time period, only 12 were considered
9 competitive. And if you look at those 12, four of those
10 had no opposing candidate in the general.

11 Candidates from both major parties are
12 represented in the 78 uncompetitive elections. And I
13 realize that rural areas tend to lean more Republican and
14 urban areas more Democrat, and thus some self-sorting does
15 occur. However, with voter registration in Pennsylvania
16 about equal among the two major parties -- with a slight
17 advantage to the Democrats right now -- and about
18 10 percent of voters registered as independents, many areas
19 of the moderate or swing voters across the state and
20 pockets of red in blue areas and pockets of blue in red
21 areas in the Commonwealth. There should be a greater
22 effort to construct more competitive districts whenever
23 possible. To do otherwise, continues to marginalize
24 hundreds of thousands of voters, eliminates their voices
25 from the conversation, and perpetuates their frustration

1 with and distrust of our legislators and legislative
2 institutions.

3 Second, unnecessary division of counties --
4 in congressional redistricting, all states must comply with
5 federal requirements for districts of equal population and
6 protections for ethnic and racial minorities. However, the
7 general assembly has not enacted constitutional or
8 statutory standards to prevent unfair partisan
9 gerrymandering of the congressional districts of the kind I
10 believe has occurred far too often in the Commonwealth.
11 And I'm going to use Dauphin County and the 2011
12 congressional map as an example.

13 Dauphin County, with a population of 268,100
14 in the 2010 census was split into three congressional
15 districts: 4, 11, and 15.

16 District 15 stretched from the corner of
17 Dauphin County to the New Jersey border near Easton. It
18 included parts of Berks, Dauphin, Lebanon, and Northampton
19 Counties, and all of Lehigh County.

20 District 11 stretched from the western
21 border of Cumberland County near Shippensburg to the
22 northern border of Wyoming County to include parts of six
23 counties and three more entire counties.

24 District 4 included Adams and York Counties,
25 the eastern part of Cumberland County, and crossed the

1 Susquehanna River to include parts of Harrisburg City and
2 Susquehanna Township in Dauphin County. Susquehanna
3 Township was divided with Ward 1 and part of Ward 3 in
4 District 4 and the remainder of the township in District
5 11. Harrisburg City was divided with Ward 1 in District 11
6 and the remainder of Harrisburg in District 4. And West
7 Hanover Township was split between Districts 11 and 15.
8 These divisions caused voter confusion and extra taxpayer
9 expense and split, what some would call, all communities of
10 interest.

11 In its 2018 decision, the Pennsylvania
12 Supreme Court applied essentially the same standards that
13 our state constitution requires for legislative
14 redistricting, and the Court said, "Congressional
15 redistricts should be," and I quote, "composed of compact
16 and contiguous territory as nearly equal in population as
17 practicable and which do not divide any county, city,
18 incorporated town, borough, township, or ward except where
19 necessary to ensure equality of population."

20 Dauphin County has a population of 286,401
21 according to the 2020 census. Based on population, it is
22 possible to keep the county whole within one congressional
23 district. It should be combined with other counties or
24 areas with similar demographics, concerns, and issues, and
25 if at all possible, should remain whole.

1 The current Congressional District 10 serves
2 as a good example for the new congressional district. It
3 encompasses the tri-county capital region of Dauphin,
4 eastern Cumberland, and northern York Counties with similar
5 issues, shared commerce, and economic concerns. It has a
6 mix of rural, suburban, and urban populations and similar
7 numbers of registered voters of both major parties. It has
8 independents and other nonaffiliated categories. It was
9 also a district with one of the very few competitive races
10 in both 2018 and 2020, with 51.3 percent Republicans to
11 48.7 Democrat, and 53.3 Republican to 46.7 Democrat,
12 respectively. The new district should also not include
13 parts of multiple counties such as was done in 2011.

14 However, if a division is considered
15 absolutely necessary, it should not be divided more than
16 once, it should not be done to favor a party or a
17 candidate, and an attempt to achieve reasonably competitive
18 districts should be made.

19 Third, division of school districts -- when
20 the 2011 congressional districts were drawn, 5 of the 12
21 Dauphin County school districts were divided between two
22 congressmen. Avoiding divisions of school districts in
23 congressional districts should be an important
24 consideration. In many cases, the residents have common
25 interests, concerns, and values. In addition, having

1 multiple legislators representing a school district
2 potentially hinders the ability to have their specific
3 concerns and needs heard and addressed.

4 In summary, the districts you draw will
5 impact legislative agenda, policy, and Pennsylvania
6 politics, thus the constituents of this Commonwealth, for
7 at least the next decade. I ask that you take into serious
8 consideration whenever possible the following: Election
9 choice and competitiveness, division of counties, and
10 division of school districts. It is also crucial that the
11 public be given ample time to review the preliminary map
12 and adequately -- an adequate opportunity for comment so
13 that adjustments can be made in completion of the final
14 map.

15 The opportunity to make a historic, positive
16 impact on PA congressional redistricting and restoration of
17 the public trust and confidence rests in your hands. This
18 must be a bipartisan effort with input from our Republican
19 and Democrat legislators. I commend your efforts at
20 transparency and public hearings thus far. However, it is
21 not what is said but the end result that will determine
22 your success.

23 Citizens are calling for transparency,
24 accountability, meaningful public input, and well-defined,
25 sensible map-drawing criteria. They are counting on you.

1 Thank you again for the opportunity to speak
2 with you this afternoon and good luck in your endeavors.

3 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you, Jean,
4 so much for your time this afternoon and appreciate your
5 input.

6 Our next testifier is Kathy Yorkievitz.

7 MS. YORKIEVITZ: That's right.

8 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Probably should
9 just stop while I'm ahead -- National Association for
10 Social Workers from Mechanicsburg, Pennsylvania.

11 Thank you so much for your time this
12 afternoon on testifying. When you are comfortable and
13 ready, please begin, and just make sure that little green
14 light is on so we can all hear you.

15 MS. YORKIEVITZ: All right. Thank you.

16 Good afternoon, Chairman Conklin, Chairman
17 Grove. We really appreciate the opportunity to be here
18 today.

19 I'm speaking on behalf of the Pennsylvania
20 chapter of the National Association of Social Workers in
21 Pennsylvania. NASW Pennsylvania has just over 4,000
22 members. We provide a range of crucial services in the
23 Commonwealth, including but not limited to, connecting
24 individuals to social services resources, individual and
25 family therapy, policy analysis, community organizing, and

1 research. The range of experiences in our profession's
2 code of ethics informed our 2021 legislative agenda,
3 adopted by the board of directors.

4 A key component of our agenda is our
5 commitment to end partisan gerrymandering. NASW
6 Pennsylvania supports efforts to improve representation for
7 all Pennsylvanians through fair, independent legislative
8 redistricting designed on a nonpartisan basis that will
9 lead to a general assembly that is more responsive to the
10 needs of all residents of the state.

11 We are very appreciative that your committee
12 has provided the opportunity for the public to be heard
13 through these public hearings and to submit maps that meet
14 the requirements of maintaining communities of interest in
15 the same district.

16 As you are aware, congressional districts
17 are vital to ensuring the voices and experiences of all
18 Pennsylvanians are represented in Congress and that federal
19 money is allotted to districts based on their need. A
20 transparent process that maintains communities of interest
21 is vital in promoting trust and participation in our
22 government, which is crucial for all of us, but most
23 essentially for our vulnerable residents. This year we
24 lost a congressional seat, which, of course, elevates the
25 importance of a transparent redistricting process.

1 As you know, on August 24th of this year,
2 the Pennsylvania Legislative Reapportionment Commission
3 voted to end the practice of counting prisoners as
4 residents of the prison rather than their last known
5 residential address. We encourage your committee to adopt
6 this same practice when drawing lines for our congressional
7 districts. Individuals who are incarcerated
8 disproportionately come from under-resourced communities.
9 Counting prisoners of their last known address will
10 increase the flow of federal resources to these
11 communities, an important step in addressing the inequities
12 in the criminal/legal system.

13 We also embrace these important values in
14 your deliberations. Continue to operate with transparency
15 and embrace maximum public input. Follow the same
16 principles for drawing congressional districts as those set
17 forth in the Pennsylvania Constitution for state
18 legislative districts, and that is, districts must be
19 composed of compact and contiguous territory as nearly
20 equal in population as possible. Unless absolutely
21 necessary, no county, city, incorporated town, borough,
22 township, or ward shall be divided.

23 We also ask that you heed the
24 recommendations of 2019 Pennsylvania Redistricting Reform
25 Commission to protect racial and language minorities

1 against discrimination by prohibiting packing and cracking,
2 outlining district plans designed to correct incumbents, or
3 discriminate against political parties.

4 In order to achieve this in drawing these
5 maps, the Commission should not consider addresses of any
6 individual, political affiliation of registered voters in
7 previous election results, unless required by federal law.

8 And since I have a little more time, I'd
9 like to just elaborate a bit on why NASW Pennsylvania wants
10 to see the congressional reapportionment process count
11 incarcerated citizens in the district of origin. There's
12 several reasons for this.

13 First, it's consistent with how we look at
14 other mobile populations. College students can now choose
15 to report their campus address or their permanent address
16 on the census form. They can be, and sometimes are, active
17 members of the community where they attend college. And
18 they can also be active in the community where they grew
19 up. Military personnel who are stationed abroad can be
20 counted in their home of record for purposes of
21 reapportionment.

22 Prisoners are kind of like that. They
23 reside in severely restricted physical settings with
24 restricted social interactions. They are not able to be
25 active participants in the community which houses the

1 prison. They keep their social ties with their home
2 community. And even dealings with the court system is back
3 in their home counties. When they earn parole, they return
4 to their home counties.

5 Second, we think it's inconsistent with
6 Pennsylvania law that states specifically that "no
7 individual who is confined in a penal institution shall be
8 deemed a resident of the election district where the
9 institution is located. The individual shall be deemed to
10 reside where the individual was last registered before
11 being confined in the penal institution."

12 Third, it distorts representation in
13 Congress. The distortion is not as significant as it can
14 be in drawing smaller state House and Senate districts, but
15 nonetheless, it artificially inflates the population count
16 in areas of the state that have state and federal
17 correction facilities, and that causes overrepresentation.
18 In the regions of the state that have higher incarceration
19 rates have less representation.

20 The residents of Philadelphia County, for
21 example, are more than three times as likely to be
22 imprisoned than the average resident of the state and more
23 than seven times as likely to be one of the residents of
24 the prison hosting Somerset and Huntingdon Counties.

25 Twelve percent of the state's population is

1 in Philly, but 40 percent of the state prisoners are from
2 that city. At the same time, 99 percent of the state
3 prison cells are located outside of Philadelphia. It's
4 true for a few other counties, like Dauphin, where there
5 are a disproportionate number of residents imprisoned in
6 other counties.

7 Fourth, this methodology discriminates
8 against minority populations by diluting their vote.
9 Blacks are more than nine times as likely to be imprisoned
10 as white people in the Commonwealth, but the state and
11 federal prison cells are located in disproportionately
12 white counties. As you're undoubtedly aware, nearly
13 50 percent -- 46 percent of those incarcerated in
14 Pennsylvania are African American, though they make up only
15 11 percent of the state's population.

16 Hispanic individuals make up only 6 percent
17 of the state population and they make up 15 percent of the
18 incarcerated population. So counting them in the community
19 where their prison is located means that residents of
20 districts with high incarceration rates have less
21 representation. The net effect is communities of color are
22 way underrepresented.

23 Finally, it makes no sense to use one
24 methodology to count incarcerated citizens for
25 reapportionment for state House and Senate districts and

1 another entirely different methodology for congressional
2 reapportionment.

3 While we're disappointed that the state's
4 reapportionment commission has chosen to implement only a
5 partial solution to prison gerrymandering, it's nonetheless
6 movement in the right direction. We urge the committee to
7 follow suit.

8 Thank you for this opportunity to talk.

9 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you, Kathy,
10 so much for your time and willingness to testify. We
11 greatly appreciate it.

12 Our next testifier is Samuel Cressler,
13 Chairman of Southampton Township, Franklin County,
14 Shippensburg, Pennsylvania.

15 Thank you so much, Mr. Cressler, for coming.
16 We appreciate your time. And when you're comfortable and
17 ready, please begin and just make sure that little green
18 light is on.

19 MR. CRESSLER: Thank you. Thank you,
20 Chairman Grove, Chairman Conklin.

21 Paul, always a pleasure.

22 My name is Samuel Cressler, and I am a
23 chairman of Southampton Township, Franklin County, where
24 I've served now for 23 years. I am also chairman of the
25 Franklin County NPO. And I missed this and was alerted

1 that I'm also vice-chairman of the Franklin County Council
2 of Governments, and a board member of the Pennsylvania
3 State Association of Township Supervisors.

4 When I look for the best representation
5 scenario for the people I serve and those I represent, I
6 see a couple of scenarios that are good and one that is
7 definitely not in our best interest.

8 Focusing in on just our township,
9 Southampton Township, Franklin County is drilling down too
10 far for a district of this size. My comments are all going
11 to be related to the political subdivision of Franklin
12 County.

13 The first positive scenario is including the
14 entire county in an eastern swing district that may include
15 counties like Cumberland, Adams, et cetera. The benefit of
16 this redistricting is economic. We share many attributes
17 with those folks like transportation, infrastructure, job
18 growth, and with Cumberland, a mutual topography in the
19 Cumberland Valley.

20 The second positive scenario is including
21 the entire county in a western swing district. That may
22 include counties like Fulton, Bedford, et cetera. The
23 benefit of this redistricting is societal. We share many
24 attributes with those folks in our enjoyment of a more
25 rural and bucolic environment.

1 The redistricting scenario that would not be
2 of any benefit to the citizens of Franklin County would be
3 some kind of division of the county. Whether it is split
4 north or south, east or west, or even by school district,
5 all of those scenarios would lessen our voice as citizens
6 of Franklin County by reducing the importance of our voter
7 constituency.

8 In recapping my testimony, the most
9 important need I wish to convey to the committee is that
10 Franklin County should not be carved up. I feel the best
11 way for our concerns to get to Washington is being in one
12 House district.

13 I appreciate all the thought and work that
14 this committee is putting into this difficult transition,
15 and I hope that my perspective from local leadership will
16 help. Thank you.

17 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you so much
18 Chairman Cressler. We greatly appreciate your time and
19 willingness to testify this afternoon.

20 Our next testifier is Benjamin Thomas,
21 mayor, Borough of Greencastle, Greencastle, Pennsylvania.

22 Mayor, when you're comfortable and ready,
23 the floor is yours, and just make sure that little green
24 button is on.

25 MR. THOMAS: Thank you, committee members.

1 It is an honor and a privilege to be in front of you this
2 afternoon.

3 Again, my name is Ben Thomas Jr. I'm the
4 mayor of Greencastle, Franklin County, Pennsylvania. I
5 also manage Cumberland Township located in central Adams
6 County. We serve a small town you may have heard of called
7 Gettysburg, Pennsylvania.

8 Greencastle's population is 4,000. We
9 encompass just 1.6 square miles of a small urban area. We
10 are seeing significant growth throughout Franklin County,
11 South Central and southeastern Pennsylvania. Though the
12 population of the Commonwealth seems to be shrinking, our
13 demographics are dramatically increasing. Folks are moving
14 from urban cities to our areas where they can retire with
15 lower tax obligations or rent or purchase properties while
16 working from home, placing their children in better public
17 schools.

18 New residents are finding a much higher
19 quality of life with lower costs of living. For the
20 following reasons, it is imperative that any redistricting
21 decisions provide us with ample representation as the need
22 for a continued quality of life may be sustained throughout
23 Franklin County by one representative.

24 Public education, as the population will
25 demand, will see expenses for more schools, faculty,

1 support staff, and operational costs, ample infrastructure,
2 water, sewer, broadband, transportation systems, including
3 the widening of Interstate 81 that may occur not until the
4 2030s.

5 We have two dozen municipalities in Franklin
6 County, nearly three dozen in Adams County. We work
7 together. It's important to have a working relationship
8 with one congressional district representative as we
9 continue to work together. That's a huge savings cost for
10 us.

11 Borough budgets are getting even tighter,
12 though boroughs are required to provide more services as
13 the surrounding townships grow, take in tax revenues, and
14 may provide limited services. It is not the township's
15 fault; that is the Pennsylvania system.

16 Boroughs are typically the centralized hub
17 that will not grow as annexation in Pennsylvania is all but
18 extinct. Therefore, boroughs provide infrastructure to the
19 surrounding townships without the benefit of receiving the
20 tax base as is the past practice in many other states.

21 Again, single representation in Washington
22 is paramount to our survival.

23 In summary, it is imperative that
24 municipalities like the Borough of Greencastle and
25 Cumberland Township in Adams County receive ample single

1 representation from Washington, D.C., and from Harrisburg
2 for our future quality of life and our financial
3 sustainability by keeping representation in Congress
4 countywide to one.

5 Thank you very much.

6 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you so much,
7 Mayor. We really appreciate your time and willingness to
8 testify this afternoon.

9 Our next testifier is Nathan Rybner from
10 Lancaster, Pennsylvania.

11 Nathan, come on up. And when you're
12 comfortable and ready, please feel free to begin and just
13 make sure that little green button is lit.

14 MR. RYBNER: Hello. All right, I think it
15 works.

16 Hi. I just want to make a quick comment
17 that I was told my original testimony, due to the length
18 and -- I went off topic a little bit. I can leave you the
19 copy I submitted online, so...

20 Thank you, members of this committee, for
21 convening this public hearing.

22 Holding this hearing makes certain that the
23 residents of the South Central Pennsylvania region have an
24 impact on this redistricting process, and through this
25 process, an impact on who represents us in

1 Washington, D.C., for the next decade.

2 My name is Nathan Rybner. As a 20-year-old
3 resident of Manheim Township, Pennsylvania, I am also a
4 resident of Lancaster County, Pennsylvania. I'm concerned
5 about the future of the United States Congressional 11th
6 House District.

7 For the past decade, there has been a
8 noticeable increase in population in South Central
9 Pennsylvania. Our municipality has not escaped this
10 population growth and neither has our county. And we are
11 much more populated compared to 10 years ago during the
12 last redistricting process.

13 I would like to talk about my federal house
14 district.

15 I believe some fellow residents of Manheim
16 Township, Pennsylvania, are copying and pasting the same
17 letter. I believe this letter has been provided by a
18 special interest and national organization. This national
19 organization wants you to believe that we should draw
20 Manheim Township, Lancaster City into the same house
21 district as York City, Harrisburg, and the immediate
22 Harrisburg suburbs drawing out and cutting out the rural
23 areas of our respective regions. I don't believe it to be
24 in the interest of Pennsylvania to do this.

25 This suggestion would be to create a

1 suggestion where we would see a quote/unquote, "Goofy
2 kicking Donald Duck." This -- I don't believe it to be in
3 the interest of Pennsylvania for us to put us back in the
4 history books for horrific gerrymandering.

5 My recommendation for our federal house
6 district is either keep it similar to what we have now,
7 drawing in more of York County, or what I recommend, to
8 draw in what we historically have done over the last two
9 centuries and draw in parts of southern Chester County. I
10 personally recommend the latter.

11 If you draw a federal legislative map that
12 respects local community boundaries and meets the
13 population average, draw a district that keeps the entirety
14 of Lancaster County together.

15 Finally, I would like to -- I would like to
16 urge you to take the genuine word of a constituent, not
17 that of a national organization trying to disrupt local
18 communities. We have a nice, beautiful, quiet community,
19 and we currently have nice districts, but due to population
20 increases, we simply need moderate adjustments to account
21 for these population increases. We don't need a chaotic
22 makeover of our county and state.

23 Thank you, and God bless you all.

24 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you. And I
25 think you win the award for the youngest testifier to date.

1 So, one, thank you for your interest, in being such a young
2 person, and thank you for giving such astute testimony.

3 Sherri is right behind you and you can just
4 give it to her.

5 Thank you, Nathan, so much. We appreciate
6 your willingness to testify this evening.

7 MR. RYBNER: (Inaudible.)

8 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Yeah.

9 Our next testifier is Christopher Fromme,
10 Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania.

11 And you probably get the award for the
12 longest drive, Chris.

13 MR. FROMME: Yep.

14 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: And when you're
15 comfortable and ready, please feel free to begin.

16 MR. FROMME: My name is Christopher Fromme,
17 and I'm from Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. It was a long
18 drive.

19 For those of you don't know, I testified at
20 the August 25th hearing in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. And
21 if you look at your package, it only shows one district,
22 but I have put together a plan for all 17 districts which
23 the committee has a copy of. They meet all the
24 requirements of being the exact number of 764,865 or
25 764,864.

1 In some cases, the data will show that a
2 very small number of people had to be moved to meet this
3 goal. I submit that these should be kids and not vote in
4 the next 10 years, because -- and this is not in there.
5 According to the census, kids under five are about
6 5 percent of the population. So in Congressional
7 District 17 -- I was so close, I only had to move 25 people
8 to Congressional District 14. In Congressional District
9 15, I only had to move 38 to Congressional District 13.
10 Congressional District 12, I had to give 17 to
11 Congressional District 11. Congressional District 6, 90 to
12 Congressional District 4. That's all under, in the
13 5 percent range, so -- and in Philadelphia, I was so good,
14 it was only 6.

15 And a caveat, I looked at what the Supreme
16 Court did. They made a mess of Philadelphia in 2018.

17 Do not make it difficult for people that
18 vote and the judges of elections. Some areas did have a
19 large split. I saw no way to avoid this. I used no
20 mapping software because I have an old computer. Just
21 Google Maps to make sure that districts were not
22 gerrymandered.

23 My other goal was to fix the mess and
24 confusion created by the Supreme Court plan of 2018 which
25 cut up so many neighborhoods. I've been working on this

1 since August 25th until October 5th.

2 The only thing the committee needs to do is
3 determine the census blocks for the areas that have larger
4 splits. And if you can find places that prefer making
5 splits -- maybe I made a mistake, whatever, go for it.

6 Lastly, I would like to thank Amanda Holt
7 for providing me with help in sending the census data and a
8 Philadelphia map.

9 And then, after listening to the testimony,
10 I'd also like to -- I'd also add a note. I did not know
11 the precinct in Plymouth Township in Congressional
12 District 5 so I just, I basically put a number there. I
13 honestly didn't -- I didn't have the time or couldn't
14 figure out what area. So I just put a number in Plymouth
15 Township in Congressional District 5.

16 And I also have to -- after listening to the
17 testimony, I have to agree with several of the people that
18 testified. The first two gentlemen that talked about their
19 particular areas, that they did not want to split up -- I
20 believe Lebanon Township -- or Lebanon County and Lancaster
21 County. Well, in my plan, they're not. They're --
22 Meuser's district is basically is -- it's basically is five
23 counties with a little bit less than, a little bit taken
24 off of Carbon County.

25 And two people that testified recently from

1 Franklin County, basically, I agree with them also.
2 Franklin County is part of one district. It isn't split
3 up, so I have to agree with them too.

4 So that's it. My work speaks for itself. I
5 worked very hard at this, hundreds of hours.

6 Thank you.

7 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you,
8 Christopher Fromme, really appreciate all your work and due
9 diligence in putting a complete map together. Thank you so
10 much.

11 Our next testifier is Michael Ross, Franklin
12 County Area Development Corporation, Chambersburg,
13 Pennsylvania.

14 Mr. Ross, when you're comfortable and ready,
15 feel free to begin and just make sure that little green
16 light is on.

17 MR. ROSS: First of all, I want to thank the
18 committee for inviting me today. It's always good to see
19 Representative Schemel. I saw him this morning. So it was
20 a good meeting then, hopefully this will be good.

21 As a matter of introduction, I am Mike Ross,
22 president of the Franklin County Area Development
23 Corporation. It's a position I've had since the FCADC
24 started up in 1986. The FCADC is a certified economic
25 development organization whose mission is to formulate,

1 implement, and promote economic strategies for Franklin
2 County that emphasize plan growth and family-sustaining
3 employment.

4 Our efforts are concentrated on the
5 retention and expansion of existing companies, the
6 selective attraction of new industries, and the start-up of
7 new businesses. Over the last 35 years, we've supported
8 more than 800 development projects that have led to more
9 than \$2 billion of capital investments and the
10 creation/retention of more than 50,000 jobs.

11 Legislative districting at both the federal
12 and state levels have profound consequences for local
13 government, both county and municipal and service
14 providers, especially an establishment of meaningful
15 relationships with elected representatives. Those
16 relationships are critical to efforts for accessing limited
17 resources in support of everything from agriculture to
18 education to infrastructure to human services.

19 For that reason, I am strongly recommending
20 that Franklin County remain in whole in the 13th
21 Congressional District currently represented by Dr. John
22 Joyce.

23 Some may be surprised by my recommendation
24 given Franklin County's location and economy. There's no
25 county more south centrally located than Franklin and none

1 more peripheral to the political alignment of what is
2 perceived to be South Central Pennsylvania. The perception
3 of the region, which has been widely created by the media,
4 is a Harrisburg-York-Lancaster triangle, which in addition
5 to Dauphin, York, and Lancaster Counties includes
6 Cumberland, Lebanon, Perry, and Adams Counties. News
7 coverage typically cuts off at Carlisle, unless there's a
8 significant traffic accident on I-81 or one of our local
9 high schools is competing for a state championship.

10 Having had this conversation with elected
11 and bureaucratic policymakers for the last 35 years, I can
12 attest, little is known about Franklin County.

13 Traversed by I-81, Franklin County is among
14 the 10 fastest growing counties in Pennsylvania with a
15 population of 155,932 people but is still substantially
16 smaller in population and more rural than Cumberland,
17 Dauphin, and York Counties.

18 Franklin County is one of the leading
19 agricultural counties in the state, especially as it
20 relates to dairy and fruit production. The county is
21 uniquely positioned as part of a four-state regional
22 economy that also includes Washington County, Maryland,
23 Hagerstown; Berkeley County, West Virginia, Martinsburg;
24 and Frederick County, Virginia, Winchester. Our quad-state
25 tagline is "four states, four counties, 40 miles."

1 As a quad-state region, we share I-81
2 proximity to Washington, D.C., and a common labor shed.
3 Economically, Franklin County is as connected to the
4 quad-state region, in many ways more so than the other
5 counties in South Central Pennsylvania. Our quad-state
6 economy is interconnected and expanding significantly; yet
7 coincidentally, each of the quad-state counties is
8 marginally on the radar of policymakers in the respective
9 states.

10 Historically, Franklin County has been part
11 of the same congressional district for decades. Formally a
12 part of the 9th Congressional District until the 2010
13 redistricting when it became the 13th district, Franklin
14 has grown to be the biggest county in the district, and
15 with all due respect to the others, the most vibrant
16 economy due to our I-81 location.

17 Our position is the largest and most vibrant
18 county in the district demands that our congressional
19 representative be actively engaged in issues and
20 initiatives impacting us. Since his election in 2018,
21 Congressman Joyce, like his predecessors Bill and Bud
22 Shuster, has been actively engaged across the county on
23 projects like Herbruck's Poultry Ranch, a \$100 million ag
24 investment in Mercersburg, to the expansions of JLG
25 Industries and Martin's Potato Rolls, and in support for

1 the Letterkenny Army Depot, WellSpan Health, Shippensburg,
2 and Penn State Mont Alto Universities, as well as Wilson
3 College.

4 I mention congressional support for
5 Letterkenny. Letterkenny is the only major defense
6 installation in the 13th district and, as such, has the
7 full attention of our congressman. If Franklin County was
8 redistricted to become part of the current 10th district
9 encompassing South Central Pennsylvania, it would be one of
10 four installations and would not have the same political or
11 economic importance.

12 Should there be a future BRAC, the depot
13 could easily be a target for closure or downsizing. And if
14 so, it would be difficult for the 10th district
15 representative to make an economic development argument
16 given it would be one of four in his or her district. As
17 the only installation in the 13th district, a predominantly
18 rural district, the economic impact is more easily
19 quantified and impactful.

20 To that point, according to an economic
21 impact analysis commissioned by the Pennsylvania Military
22 Community Enhancement Commission, the Letterkenny Army
23 Depot has a \$1.75 billion annual economic impact on
24 Franklin County. Removing that impact would have a
25 devastating effect on Franklin County and have a severe

1 ripple effect on the overall 13th district.

2 However, if we were a part of the 10th
3 district, the consequences for Franklin County would be the
4 same, however it would have a far less impact on the rest
5 of the 10th district.

6 In conclusion, being a part of the 13th
7 district, in total, the county in total in my opinion has
8 served Franklin County extremely well, and I strongly
9 recommend our continued inclusion.

10 With that, thank you.

11 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you so much,
12 Mr. Ross. We greatly appreciate your time this afternoon
13 and your willingness to testify on such an important issue.

14 Our next testifier is Ricardo Almodovar,
15 Campus Vote Project, Lancaster, Pennsylvania.

16 How'd I do on your last name?

17 MR. ALMODOVAR: Close.

18 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Close, all right.
19 All right. Thank you. And when you're comfortable and
20 ready, please feel free to begin and just make sure that
21 little green light is on.

22 MR. ALMODOVAR: All right.

23 Hi, good evening. My name is Ricardo
24 Almodovar. I have strong roots in South Central
25 Pennsylvania. I was born and raised in Lancaster. And I'm

1 a product of social services and the public school system
2 in the school district of Lancaster. I went to McCaskey
3 High School, the most diverse high school in Lancaster
4 County and graduated from Millersville University in 2016.

5 After years of community organizing, public
6 policy, and civic engagement work, I'm continuing my
7 education as a grad student in the masters of social work
8 program at Millersville. I am currently the Pennsylvania
9 State Coordinator for the Campus Vote Project of the Fair
10 Election Center. We are a national nonpartisan
11 organization that works with campuses across the country to
12 institutionalize programming, to help students to register
13 to vote, cast their ballots, and be civically engaged in
14 their communities.

15 In Pennsylvania alone, we currently work
16 with over 32 institutions. Students are getting involved,
17 and we are paying attention to the redistricting process
18 now more than ever. I'm here today to urge the committee
19 to recognize colleges and universities as communities of
20 interest as you move through the redistricting process for
21 these congressional maps.

22 Our existing maps should not be used as a
23 starting place in this process. There are years of
24 inequality drawn into them. Political maps drawn in 2021
25 should reflect the changing demographics of our

1 Commonwealth.

2 According to the National Study of Learning,
3 Voting, and Engagement, the voting rate of college students
4 in our Commonwealth grew from 15.9 percent in the 2014
5 midterm election to 37 percent in the 2018 midterm
6 elections. And this rate is expected to be even higher
7 once we receive the 2020 data.

8 College students are a key demographic group
9 with shared interests, and their campuses must be viewed as
10 communities of interest. Unfortunately, these maps failed
11 to take these communities into account and have split
12 campuses into multiple districts.

13 Pennsylvania's colleges and universities are
14 communities, and students and campus administrators have
15 shared their concern with us at the Campus Vote Project.
16 They said repeatedly that they feel left out of this
17 process. We are working diligently to make a change, and
18 that is why I urge you to take the redistricting process on
19 campuses into consideration.

20 Redistricting must not be a partisan issue.
21 The new maps that you create should be drawn with the
22 interests of all Pennsylvanians in mind, guided by a
23 commitment to racial equity and full representation for
24 all. College-age voters, particularly persons of color,
25 deserve the opportunity to elect representatives that will

1 be responsive to the interests and concerns of their
2 communities.

3 This community is charged with an incredibly
4 important task, and residents in the Commonwealth will
5 remember. We ask that you draw maps that represent the
6 needs of Pennsylvania's population and all of the
7 communities of interest.

8 Democracy works best with maximum
9 participation, and we demand fair and just maps. No one
10 can proudly proclaim they support democracy when their goal
11 in drawing the district lines is to maintain power by
12 diluting votes. No one can claim to support equality while
13 they work tirelessly to dilute and minimize black and brown
14 voters, and the people will see the truth.

15 Thank you for your time. Have a good day.

16 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you,
17 Ricardo, so much for your time and willingness to testify
18 this afternoon.

19 Just to let you know, this is our second
20 hearing at a college or university in the Commonwealth. So
21 duly noted.

22 Our last testifier for this evening is Gary
23 Laird, Hanover Area Chamber of Commerce, Hanover,
24 Pennsylvania.

25 Gary, come on down, and when you're

1 comfortable and ready, please feel free to begin and just
2 make sure that the little green light is on.

3 MR. LAIRD: Good afternoon. Thank you for
4 the opportunity to be here today.

5 My name is Gary Laird. I'm president of the
6 Hanover Area Chamber of Commerce. I've been with the
7 chamber for about 20 years. And I also am a small business
8 owner in York County, and I employ about 30 employees.

9 So I'm here to share a bit of our
10 perspective from a business standpoint and the importance
11 of redistricting in our area.

12 When you look at the location of Hanover,
13 just a little bit to the west of here, we're right on the
14 fringe of District 11. When you evaluate the economic
15 footprint of that area, most people look at Hanover and
16 they see a population base of about 15,000 people. That's
17 true in one municipality. When you look at the service
18 footprint of what we consider to be our local economic
19 footprint, it's actually 11 municipalities in two counties
20 with a population base of about 70,000. That's comparable
21 in size to a lot of third-class cities in the Commonwealth
22 of Pennsylvania.

23 During my time at the chamber and living in
24 the Hanover area, I've seen considerable growth over the
25 last 20 years. A lot of that influenced by, from the

1 Maryland markets, a lot of it influenced, probably most
2 significantly influenced by our growth in manufacturing and
3 our commercial growth that we've recognized for many, many
4 years as well.

5 We're located in an area that is very
6 divided. Even York County is divided. And when you look
7 at the flow of commerce in South Central PA, our area
8 represents about a third of the tax base in York County.

9 I think it's important that we be more
10 closely aligned, from an economic and commerce standpoint,
11 when we look at our congressional districts. We have four
12 areas that I think are critical for this reason --
13 municipal planning, infrastructure development, education,
14 and workforce development, and really representing the
15 business interests in South Central Pennsylvania.

16 I would ask the committee and the general
17 assembly to consider aligning York County entirely as one
18 district and also Adams County. Because when you look at
19 the flow, again from an economic development standpoint, a
20 transportation standpoint, in both Adams and York Counties,
21 they need to be a lot more closely aligned.

22 So I appreciate, again, the opportunity to
23 be here today, and I would hope that you'd give
24 consideration to aligning York County into one
25 congressional district and Adams County as well.

1 So thank you very much.

2 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: Thank you, Gary,
3 so much for your time and willingness to testify this
4 afternoon.

5 With that, that was the last testifier.

6 I do want to add, we did -- I did miss one
7 written testimony we did receive from Tom Palisin, York
8 County Manufacturers' Association, York, Pennsylvania.
9 That will be updated with the packets when they are sent
10 out.

11 Any closing remarks?

12 DEMOCRATIC CHAIRMAN CONKLIN: As always, I
13 just want to thank the committee, and most of all, I want
14 to thank the participants for coming out today. It really
15 means a lot to us.

16 Thank you.

17 MAJORITY CHAIRMAN GROVE: I echo that, thank
18 our testifiers for your input on this important -- the
19 importance of the impact of a redistricting process has on
20 our communities. I also want to thank the members in
21 attendance today, and our guest senator, as well as our
22 host, York College.

23 I hope it is evident that the House of
24 Representatives is committed to undertaking the most open,
25 transparent, accountable redistricting process in

1 Pennsylvania history. We believe that transparency and
2 accountability form the bedrock of good governance, and
3 input through these hearings plays an essential role in
4 that.

5 I look forward to continuing the public
6 process in other regions of the Commonwealth in the coming
7 weeks. And I invite those members in attendance or viewing
8 at home today to follow those hearings as well.

9 With that, we are adjourned. Thank you
10 again.

11 (The hearing concluded at 5:25 p.m.)
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C E R T I F I C A T I O N

I hereby certify that the proceedings are
contained fully and accurately in the notes taken by me on
the within proceedings, and that this copy is a correct
transcript of the same.

Summer A. Miller

Summer A. Miller, Court Reporter
Notary Public